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The 1570s were not quite modern times, of course. Doubt may have flourished in the curious emperor's court, allowing him access to a wealth of learning and giving him a weapon by which to clip the wings of his powerful clergy, but doubt is a double-edged sword. Scepticism is the antidote to blind belief but also to absolute power – and if Akbar wanted to reduce the authority of his ulema, he desired no such bounds to his own.

Indeed, Abul Fazl's very rational precept regarding doubt goes hand in-and with a code of mystic belief: The debating scholars, as he wrote, 'think that knowledge is only to be had in schools. They do not know that much of acquired learning is subject to doubt and scepticism.' All knowledge can bear examination, that is; but knowledge is not the same as revelation. Thus, Abul Fazl declares in his very next sentence: 'It is clear that a pure heart can be enlightened without book learning . . .'[25]

At the very time, therefore, that religious debate raged in Fatehpur, a new kind of faith began to develop across the realm in the superhuman powers of the enlightened emperor himself.

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No one can doubt that Akbar was lucky. It was a chance arrow that blinded Hemu and allowed Akbar the Delhi throne; it was an accident that tripped Ikhtiyar-ul-Mulk's horse and saved the exhausted Mughals from a second battle outside Ahmedabad; and it must have been good fortune that made it rain just as that delegation of farmers pleaded with Akbar in Jaunpur.

Soon after, in March 1575, the Mughal generals that Akbar left behind in Patna had chased the Afghans, Daud and Gujar Khan, all the way to Tukaroi, in Orissa. The Mughal side, far from home in an unfamiliar land, was rife with dissension and indecision, yet Munim Khan managed to rally them to a fight. A battle began, but the Mughal men had little appetite for Gujar Khan's elephants, charging at them bedecked with 'black yak-tails and the skins of . . . animals',[26] presenting an even more fearsome sight than usual. Then, one of the best Mughal generals, Khan Alam, was knocked to the ground and killed by the Afghans. Munim, meanwhile, charging into battle in his eighties, came face to face with Gujar Khan but was unable to find his sword. With impressively quick thinking and